

Fly where the air is thin.

Meridian gets **one rotation**. That rules out maximising market size. The biggest markets are big *because* incumbents with slots, feed and scale already hold them. So we scored routes on **capturability**, not size:

Opportunity is demand that already exists, on planes that are already full, on a route nobody owns.

D

Demand

Is the market real?

Q4 passengers, 2015-19

G

Growth

Is it getting bigger?

vs 2010-14

S

Strain

Are the planes full?

passengers ÷ departures

R

Room

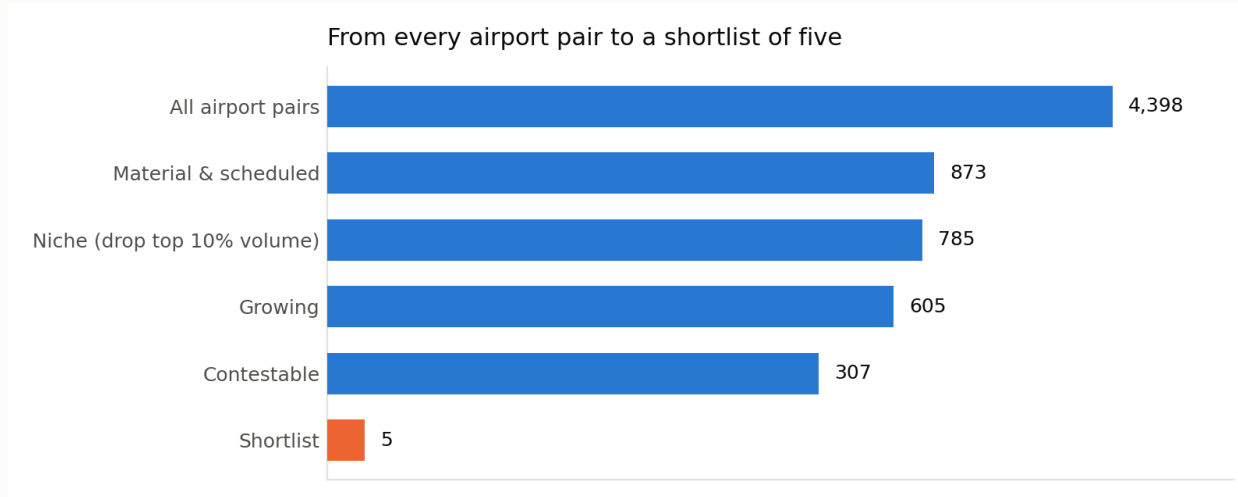
Can we get in?

1 – HHI of carrier shares

Each dial is a percentile rank inside the candidate pool, so they are unit-free and additive. **Room uses 1 – HHI, not carrier count.** Two carriers can be an open duopoly or a 97% fortress, and only concentration tells them apart.

THE FUNNEL

4,398 airport pairs → 5 finalists



- **Material & scheduled:** $\geq 50k$ Q4 passengers, present all five years, $\geq 80\%$ scheduled. A rotation needs a repeating market, not charters.
- **Niche:** drop the top decile by volume. This is the client's instruction, applied as a rule rather than argued from evidence.
- **Growing:** demand rising against 2010-14.
- **Contestable:** ≥ 2 carriers and $HHI \leq 0.90$, which removes hub fortresses like ATL-AMS and DTW-AMS that look thin but are locked.

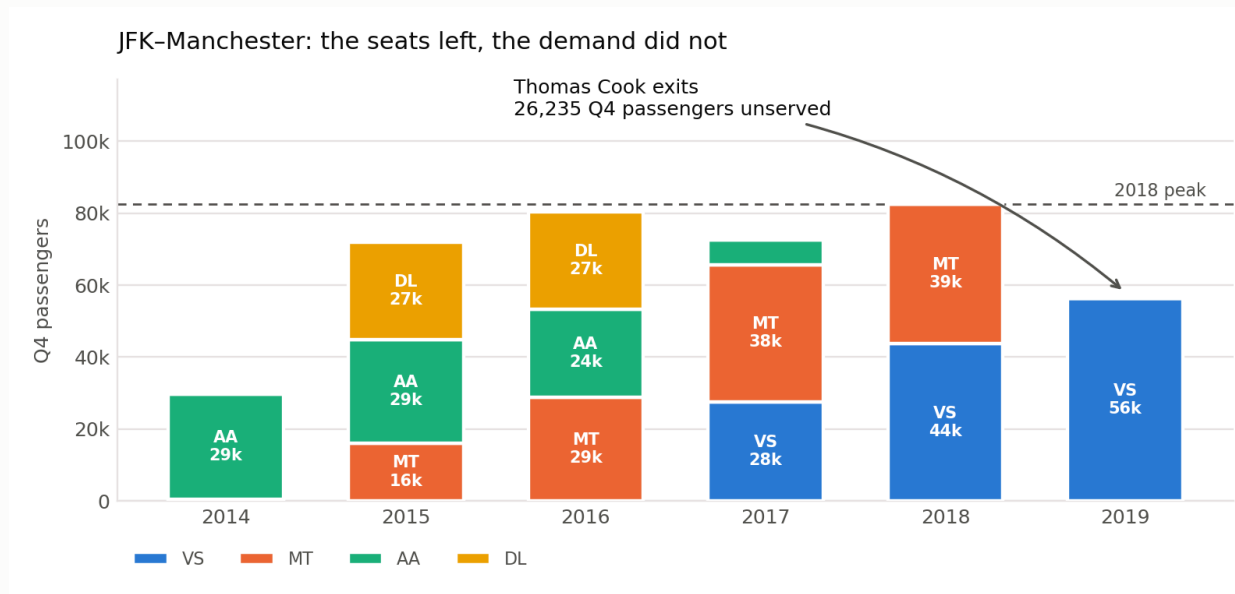
The index shortlists. It does not decide.

TAI ranks **LAX-HND first**. We reject it: Tokyo Haneda's US slots are allocated government-to-government and held by Delta, United, American and ANA. "Room" measures *concentration*. It cannot see that the seats are legally unobtainable. Three majors splitting a route evenly reads as contestable and is in fact a closed shop.

THE RECOMMENDATION

JFK ⇌ Manchester, and the reason is dated

Manchester is the UK's second gateway: the same national market as Heathrow, without the slot war Meridian cannot win. It is also the only finalist with a **catalyst**.



Thomas Cook collapsed in September 2019.

It carried **47% of the route** in 2018. Virgin Atlantic backfilled only part of it. The planes still flew **320 passengers per departure**, so the demand did not evaporate. It went unserved.

26,235

Q4 passengers of
proven demand,
unserved

0.83

departures per day
needed to carry them

26,235 ÷ 344 passengers per departure = 76 flights over 92 days. The vacated demand is almost exactly **one daily rotation**, precisely the capacity Meridian has been funded for. We are not making a market or starting a price war; we are occupying a seat someone else left.

SENSITIVITY: WHERE WE COULD BE WRONG

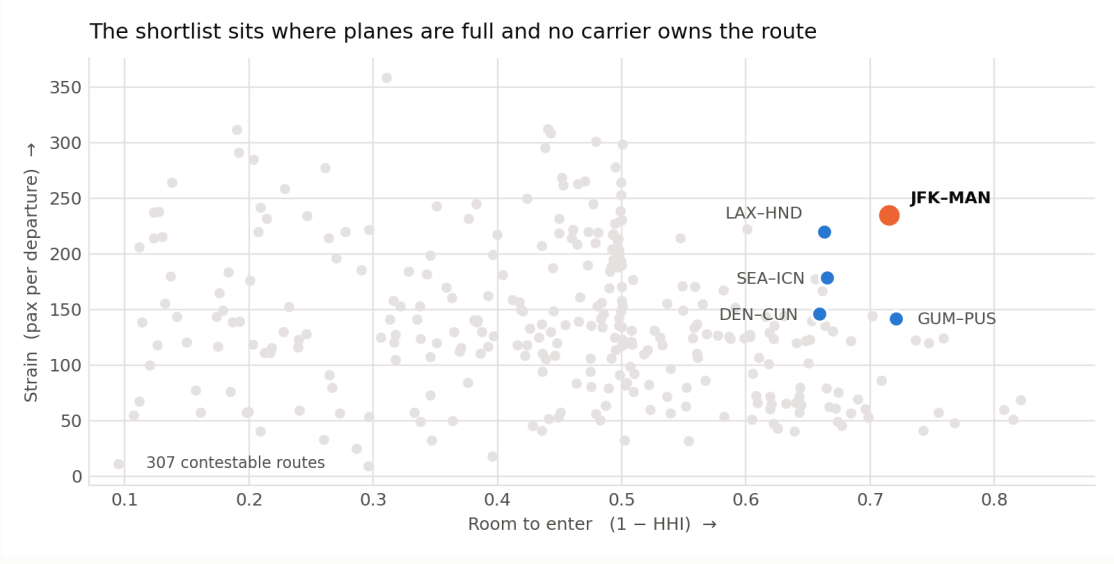
The weighting *is* the argument

WEIGHTING	TOP ROUTE	JFK-MAN
Equal (our prior)	LAX-HND	#2
Capturability-led	JFK-MAN	#1
Strain-led	JFK-MAN	#1
Room-led	JFK-MAN	#1
Growth-led	LAX-HND	#2
Size-led	LAX-HND	#24

JFK-MAN wins outright whenever **Strain** or **Room** carries real weight. That is, whenever the score reflects Meridian's actual weaknesses. Weight **size** instead and it falls to 24th. We are not hiding that; it is the whole sensitivity.

Try to break it yourself

Drag the four dials and watch the ranking re-order live:
[dashboard/index.html](#)



The single finding that would change our mind

Post-2019 schedule data showing **Manchester capacity restored to 2018 levels**. The case rests on one specific, dated vacancy. Our data stops three months after it opened. If it has been filled, the thesis is dead.

SWOT, and what this analysis cannot see

STRENGTHS

- Two profitable years, capital in hand
- No legacy network to defend; free to pick optimally
- One rotation = small, reversible commitment

WEAKNESSES

- No connecting feed, pure point-to-point
- No slot portfolio at constrained airports
- No alliance, JV or corporate contracts
- Unknown brand in every foreign market

OPPORTUNITIES

- Carrier failures vacate *proven* demand
- Secondary gateways are unslotted, under-served
- Monopoly routes carry fat, attackable fares

THREATS

- Virgin adds frequency and squeezes us
- The gap may already be backfilled
- Leisure skew → thin premium cabin, weak yield
- One route = zero diversification

LIMITATIONS OF THE DATA & METHOD

- **The files are Q4-only, and the window moves.** Passengers cover Sep-Dec then Aug-Dec; departures Oct-Dec then Sep-Dec. We forced a constant Oct-Dec window to kill the step artifacts, at the cost of the entire summer peak. Manchester is leisure-leaning, so its true annual demand is likely *understated* here.
- **The index cannot see non-concentration barriers:** slots, bilateral rights, gates, immunised JVs. This is why the top-scoring route is rejected by hand.
- **Five-year HHI hides the present.** JFK-MAN scores Room 0.70 across 2015-19, but in 2019 Virgin is the *only* carrier. We are entering a monopoly today.
- **Airport pair ≠ O&D market**, so the addressable market is smaller than the counts imply.
- **Corporate parents are invisible.** DY and DI on LAX-LGW are both Norwegian, scored as two competitors.

Assumptions: Q4 ordering approximates annual ordering; passengers ÷ departures is a usable load proxy absent seat counts; vacated demand persists rather than permanently re-routing via LHR/DUB/AMS; and history guides the launch year.